

The diplomatic gold rush

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Presented by Amazon By NICHOLAS VINOCUR with GREGORIO SORGI GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's dive in. In today's Playbook: — Ursula von der Leyen's

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's dive in.

In today's Playbook:

- Ursula von der Leyen's coalition in the European Parliament is split over Gaza funds.
- The Berlaymont is getting rattled by all the protests at the Schuman roundabout.
- Faces in the crowd: Sam Altman, Kaja Kallas, Kajsa Ollongren, Barry Andrews, Philippe Close, Robert Biedroń, Jean-Nicolas Beuze, Flávio Bolsonaro, Pete Buttigieg, Wopke Hoekstra and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Nick discuss how France's student protests are upending the presidential election campaign.

**A message from Amazon: Businesses across Europe are using the AWS Cloud to modernise essential industries. In Valmacca, Italy, xFarm uses cloud technology to help farmers make data-driven decisions, improve productivity, and support more sustainable agricultural practices—connecting farms across Europe and beyond. Hear from more AWS customers across Europe. **

DRIVING THE DAY

ANYWHERE BUT BRUSSELS: European Commission officials rushed to apply for a slew of plum jobs that are opening up in the EU's diplomatic network in the coming months, including the head of its delegation to the United Nations in New York and head of its office at the OECD in Paris, two EU officials told Playbook.

The surge of applications — described by one as a “gold rush” — coincides with reports of employee malaise and looming budget cuts at the Commission, where staff were asked to conduct scenarios in which the EU's overall development budget was cut by as much as 40%. It also reflects an ongoing turf

war between Ursula von der Leyen's European Commission and the European External Action Service (EEAS) run by Kaja Kallas over the future of EU foreign policy.

With budget cuts looming and staffers complaining about reduced autonomy in a highly centralized Commission, the appeal of ditching rainy Brussels for a far-flung locale where top jobs come with free housing and staff is more appealing than ever, the officials said.

Wish you were there? Some 30 key jobs in the EEAS' global network of about 145 delegations are up for grabs in 2027, with standouts including head of the EU's delegation to the tropical island of Mauritius, deputy head of delegation in Beijing and head of delegation in Saudi Arabia.

The juicy bit: Applicants include Commission staffers ranking as high as director-general — the highest level of EU civil servant below politically appointed commissioners — and senior national diplomats, the officials told me.

But it causes a headache: Managing the huge EEAS "rotation" is a key task facing new EEAS Secretary-General Kajsa Ollongren, who got started on Sept. 1 and has yet to replace the body's outgoing head of resource management. The recruitment process is being overseen by acting officials, Elsa Fenet and Olivier Bailly.

Ollongren is about halfway through a tour of European capitals, with more than 15 stops planned, including a trip to Warsaw last Friday geared at gathering ideas on EU foreign policy.

New sheriff in town: The new secretary-general made a strong impression during her first appearances at Coreper (meetings of ambassadors), two EU diplomats said. She is part of a new EEAS leadership team alongside France's former Ambassador to NATO David Cvach, who's now deputy secretary-general for peace, security and defense, and Estonian senior diplomat Matti Maasikas, deputy secretary-general for geoeconomics and interinstitutional issues. "Ollongren is taking her time to see who she can trust and how the system works," said one of the officials.

What's next: With pre-screening of applications now done, formal job interviews are set to run through December and January.

The bottom line: The European Commission may be winning a turf war with the EEAS, but its employees are more eager than ever to trade the Schuman roundabout for the excitement of a foreign posting.

BIG AND BREAKING

ALTMAN'S BIG TRADE-OFF: The world "should accept some bad things happening" for the benefits of artificial intelligence, OpenAI chief Sam Altman said in an exclusive interview with Decoded by POLITICO, our new global technology briefing. Altman also discussed U.S. President Donald Trump's AI accord with top tech firms, the rash of autonomous hacking incidents carried out by OpenAI models and his views on political power players including French President Emmanuel Macron.

Launching today: Decoded and its accompanying daily podcast will cover the people, policy fights and political battles reshaping tech, drawing on nearly 50 POLITICO journalists across the world. Sign up for the newsletter and subscribe to the podcast .

BOLSONARO AHEAD: Brazil's presidential race will head to a second round on Oct. 25 after Flávio Bolsonaro finished ahead of incumbent Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva in voting yesterday, but without

securing a majority. A Bolsonaro presidency could have huge consequences for the EU's relationship with Brazil and the Mercosur trade deal, as Camille Gijs wrote last week .

REDEPLOYED: The U.S. military confirmed overnight that it has withdrawn its bombers from RAF Fairford, the British air base at the center of a suspected terrorist incident late last month, my stateside colleagues report.

THE COMING ATLANTIC CLIMATE NIGHTMARE: From Reykjavík to The Hague, European governments are starting to prepare for a literal sea change that would end life as we know it on the continent, Zia Weise reports.

LEFT ALLIANCE TARGETED: The European Conservatives and Reformists are gathering signatures for a vote to ask the political-parties watchdog to investigate whether the European Left Alliance (ELA) breached EU values over the alleged role of its French member La France Insoumise in the school protests that have rocked France , according to an email seen by Max Grier.

CLASH OVER GAZA FUNDING

GAZA CRISIS DISRUPTS PARLIAMENT BUDGET TALKS: The Ursula von der Leyen-backing majority in the European Parliament is at odds over whether to fund the reconstruction of Gaza from the bloc's next seven-year budget — yet another difficulty in the negotiations that are exposing major differences between national governments .

Final countdown: This is one of the final hurdles to overcome in the Parliament, with lawmakers aiming to finalize a common position next Thursday on the Global Europe Fund, a €200 billion pot of money governing EU foreign aid. Another sensitive issue is whether to use EU money to build migrant return hubs abroad and discourage crossings to Europe.

Von der Leyen's European People's Party rejected an amendment from the Greens, seen by Playbook, to ring-fence €15 billion for Gaza in the next budget. The EPP argued that it's premature to ringfence cash for Gaza before a clear plan to rebuild the territory is agreed, said a lawmaker with knowledge of the discussions.

But the Socialists and Democrats, the Left and parts of Renew are pushing in the opposite direction from the EPP — even though the final text is unlikely to commit funding. "The most basic obligation of the EU is to provide sufficient humanitarian funding for the people of Gaza," Irish Renew MEP Barry Andrews told Playbook. Socialists and Democrats lawmaker Robert Biedroń said he was sure they'd find a "compromise that will guarantee a meaningful EU involvement in the reconstruction of Gaza. It's a priority for the S&D Group."

Sounding the alarm: Civil society groups CONCORD, EPLO and VOICE, which together represent 200 NGOs, warned that cuts to Global Europe would undermine the EU's role in the world and its response to international crises.

Jean-Nicolas Beuze, UNHCR representative to the EU, told Playbook: "We should be careful about thinking spending less abroad automatically saves us money. Sometimes you save money today and end up paying much more tomorrow, when a faraway crisis has become much bigger and harder to manage."

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Migration Commissioner Magnus Brunner has presented plans to address sudden mass arrivals on the bloc's borders, including a ramped-up role for Frontex, the EU's border agency. But what does Frontex do? It has its own uniformed law enforcement officers (the Standing Corps) that can assist national authorities. It also coordinates joint operations and gathers and shares intelligence with EU countries, as well as sending back data to its base in Warsaw.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: Zoya asked where you'd choose to be based if you could pick any EU diplomatic posting. WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

OI, URSULA!

PROTESTS ROCK THE SCHUMAN ROUNDABOUT: Noise from demos now regularly taking place on Brussels' Schuman roundabout can easily be heard on the Berlaymont's 13th floor — where Ursula von der Leyen works and often sleeps, two EU officials told Playbook.

Location, location, location: While protests have long been a feature of Brussels' EU quarter (tractors and hay bales, anyone?), rallies are being staged more frequently on the roundabout since the completion of a renovation that's managed to turn it into a flat, featureless disk. It's now ideal for protesting — like Paris's Place de la République or Maidan Square in Kyiv.

Over the past 10 days, Playbook observed — and heard — protests on the roundabout by climate activists (including an 8 a.m. "Rave against climate inaction"), animal rights activists (holding up placards with the face of Animal Welfare Commissioner Olivér Várhelyi) and steel industry advocates (featuring genuine-looking coffins).

Legal fine print: Unlike the immediate vicinity of Belgium's Royal Palace, the Federal Parliament or the prime minister's office — all "neutral zones" where protesting is illegal — there is no permanent restriction on protesting near EU buildings. Organizers must obtain an authorization from a local authority, in this case Brussels Mayor Philippe Close.

Brussels vs. the Berlaymont: "If the Brussels commune prefers, we can take this circus on the road" — i.e., to one of the bloc's other locations, said a second EU official.

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

LET US SHOOT DOWN DRONES: Governments should change laws to allow defense companies to take down suspicious drones overflying their plants, said a senior executive at Franco-German arms maker KNDS, Laura Kayali reports .

LATVIA STICKS WITH KULBERGS: Latvian Prime Minister Andris Kulbergs' United List has won the country's parliamentary election by a wide margin, putting the pro-Ukraine leader in a strong position to remain in power pending coalition negotiations.

LEADING THE GREEN CHARGE: The Greens in the European Parliament will pick new leaders tomorrow. POLITICO spoke to all the candidates .

AGAINST THE GRAIN: Some EU countries are rebuffing Ukraine's pleas to help move its grain exports through Europe, as concerns for domestic farmers trump solidarity with Kyiv, per POLITICO. And the FT reports this morning that Brussels is planning to "significantly limit" Ukraine's access to agricultural markets and farming subsidies if it joins the bloc.

Meanwhile in Kyiv ... German Chancellor Friedrich Merz announced a new aid package for Ukraine worth more than €1 billion during a surprise visit yesterday that was marked by Russian drone attacks.

VERHOFSTADT PROBE: Former Belgian Prime Minister Guy Verhofstadt is under investigation by Belgian federal prosecutors over the supervision of European Parliament interns during his time as leader of the liberal ALDE group.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Mostly sunny. High 21C.

SPOTTED ... at Bibliothèque Solvay for last week's BOLDT BPI's fifth annual Champagne Party and the launch of its new report, "Where next? EU policy between now and 2035," outlining eight crucial policy areas driving the EU over the next 10 years: BOLDT BPI's Jeremy Galbraith, Scott Mulhauser, Jo-ann Robertson, Daniel Wixforth and a hearty BPI contingent; MEP Gerben-Jan Gerbrandy; European Commission's Susanne Appel and Marijn Verhees; Camilla Gentili of the Italian permanent representation to the EU; Anna Borys of McDonald's; Google's Karen Massin; JP Morgan Chase's Valérie Hoess; Kraft Heinz's Serge Thines; Mastercard's Philipp Brüchert; Leonardo's Enrico Comin; RTX's Christopher Sage; ePURE's Craig Winneker; the Australian Embassy's Francesco Cazzini; Thomson Reuters' Foo Yun Chee; Sanofi's Sylwia Staszak; and CropLife Europe's Olivier de Matos.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: The heads of Germany's intelligence agencies will appear jointly at a parliamentary hearing , with Russia's war in Ukraine and hybrid attacks expected to feature prominently.

Paris: Education Minister Edouard Geffray will visit a high school today to show the government is in control after the wave of protests — but another mass mobilization tomorrow could bring more unrest.

London: Kemi Badenoch's frontbenchers will get a chance to step out of the Conservative leader's shadow as the party's annual conference ramps up in Birmingham.

Washington: Pete Buttigieg is stumping for Democrats in at least six states in the final stretch before the midterms, fueling talk of another presidential bid in 2028.

Ottawa: Quebec voters go to the polls today — and the result could reshape Mark Carney's relationship with the province.

Canberra: EU Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra tells Playbook en route to a pre-COP summit in Fiji that Europe's reliance on imported oil and gas is a "phenomenally large political liability."

AGENDA

— EU-Republic of Moldova Association Council in Brussels. Press conference with EU High Representative Kaja Kallas, Moldova's Prime Minister Vasile Tofan and Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos around 11:50 a.m. Watch live.

— Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Parliament President Roberta Metsola meet in Strasbourg at 4:15 p.m.

— European Parliament plenary in Strasbourg from 5 p.m. Watch live .

— von der Leyen will meet the leaders of the European People's Party (Manfred Weber), Socialists and Democrats (Iratxe García) and Renew Europe (Valérie Hayer) groups in the European Parliament.

— Metsola presides over the Parliament's Bureau at 6 p.m.

— European Council President António Costa will meet Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk in Warsaw.

— Costa will also meet Warsaw Mayor Rafał Trzaskowski and deliver a speech opening the academic year at the College of Europe's Natolin campus.

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič has a call with Dutch Foreign Trade Minister Sjoerd Sjoerdsma; and with BMW CEO Milan Nedeljković.

— Climate Commissioner Wopke Hoekstra attends the pre-COP31 ministerial meeting and leaders' event in Fiji.

— Moldova's PM Tofan also meets Energy Commissioner Dan Jørgensen and Financial Services Commissioner Maria Luís Albuquerque in Brussels.

— Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall visits Berlin, where she'll meet Germany's Environment Minister Carsten Schneider and Michael Claus, head of the European Policy Division at the Federal Chancellery.

BIRTHDAYS

MEPs Leïla Chaïbi and Paolo Inselvini; Follow the Money's Simon Van Dorpe; Miloš Labović from the Amsterdam Transport Authority; journalist Thomas Hanke; Tajikistani President Emomali Rahmon.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Amazon:** Founded to support the digital evolution of farming, xFarm uses the AWS Cloud to power a platform that helps farmers improve productivity while keeping sustainability at the core of their operations. By turning agricultural data into actionable insights, xFarm enables farmers to make smarter decisions in an increasingly complex environmental and economic landscape. "With the AWS Cloud, we can connect farms around the world, transforming agriculture through innovation while keeping sustainability at the heart of everything we do," says Giovanni Causapruno of xFarm. xFarm is one of many European businesses building on the AWS Cloud to operate at scale, strengthen resilience, and support more sustainable food systems. The AWS Cloud helps xFarm extend its impact across borders—supporting farmers as they adapt to today's environmental and operational challenges. Learn

more about how businesses across Europe are growing with the AWS Cloud at [AWS.eu](https://aws.eu). **

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